of certain foreign policies is like piecing together a puzzle. The ‘Foreign Office mind’ and ‘mental maps’; the importance of studying individuals rather than only ‘issues and impulses’; the notion of prestige and the complexity of how a nation’s power is measured; how Russia, Bolshevism and the Great Game influenced thinking – each is a piece of the picture.

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By looking briefly at the legacy of the Great Game, and then focusing in detail on the years 1918 to 1923, this work will demonstrate the continuity of thought which existed between the pre-war and post-war period. Utilising primary documents from the National Archives of the Foreign Office, the War Office and the Cabinet, together with India Office papers held at the British Library, discussion will focus on the debates which raged between London and Delhi on all aspects of British policy towards southern Asia and Russia after the end of the First World War. The annotations of Curzon on various memoranda, telegrams and reports – often scathing, sometimes witty, always entertaining – are a particular insight into the mind of the foreign secretary. The numerous letters and telegrams sent between the secretary of state for India, Edwin Montagu, and two successive viceroys, Lord Chelmsford and Lord Reading, also provide particular illumination on the relationship between the Home and the Indian governments. Personal collections of key figures such as the Chief of General Staff, Sir Henry Wilson, and the British ambassador to Tehran, Sir Percy Loraine, also help to provide background.

To be more specific, the following chapters will show that there were those within the British government – and particularly within the Foreign Office – who displayed an attitude towards Soviet Russia and southern Asia that emanated from the decades prior to the First World War. This continuity of thought was rooted in the Great Game, and it is this ‘Great Game mentality’ that informed the decision-making process of certain government officials in the post-war period. The concept of a Great Game mind-set will be